

Ecological Economics

MA Sustainable Energy & MA International Management Studies — Winter Semester 2026/27

2026-08-12

This seminar description is also available online. The most recent version — together with all session materials — is on the course website at <https://ecological-economics26.netlify.app/content/material/SeminarDescription.html>, which is also linked from the Moodle room. Please check there for updates.

1 Overall Goal of the Course

The course covers a wide range of interactions between the environment and socio-economic development. Students are introduced to various methods for analyzing economic impacts on the environment, the importance of the environment for economic activities, and the role of social institutions within the context of economy–environment relationships. In this setting, students learn about different policy tools that can address (undesired) external effects of economic activities on the environment and how to evaluate the effectiveness of environmental regulations from an economic perspective. Over the semester, students work on one particular country or region case study, which they present as a poster during a poster conference at the end of the semester.

2 Learning Goals

Upon completion of this seminar, you will be able to:

Expertise:

- Understand the core concepts and analytical perspective of ecological economics
- Explain how different notions of ‘economic development’ relate to the question of ecological sustainability
- Discuss the relevance of trade-offs between social and environmental goals
- Understand how economic activities and the resulting ecological stressors are globally interrelated

Methodological Competence:

- Work with data on socio-economic development and environmental pressures
- Account for environmental stressors at the global level, distinguishing production- and consumption-based perspectives

- Evaluate environmental policy instruments and their underlying assumptions

Social and Personal Skills:

- Conduct and present a country-level analysis as part of a group
- Be able to delineate the assumptions on which your own assessments, and those on others depend when it comes to the discussion of social and environmental challenges
- Take well-founded positions in current debates (e.g. growth vs. degrowth)

3 Course Information

3.1 Prerequisites

There are no formal prerequisites. A basic familiarity with introductory economics is helpful but not required. The course is offered jointly for the MA “Sustainable Energy” and the MA “International Management Studies” programs.

3.2 Course Details

- **Lecture Time:** Wednesdays, 08:30–12:00 (we start 8:30 sharp)
- **Lecturers:** Claudius Gräbner-Radkowsch & Anna-Katharina Kothe
- **Credits:** 5 ECTS ($\approx$ 150 h total workload; about 7 h of self-study per week on top of the weekly lecture)

3.3 Course Resources

- **Moodle Room:** [room 17919](#)
- Passwort will be distributed during the first lecture

4 Schedule and Logistics

! Important

Note: This schedule is subject to change as the course progresses. Announcements will be made via [Moodle](#). The latest version of the syllabus will be made available here.

Sessions with two topics on the same date are listed as two rows sharing that date. **Each topic links to its session page**, which holds the slides and the reading list. The two non-teaching Wednesdays (23.09. and 14.10.) are included for completeness.

#	Date	Topic	Lecturer
1	16.09.	Introduction, course logistics & example poster	Claudius & Anna-Katharina

#	Date	Topic	Lecturer
1	16.09.	Theories of socio-economic development and the environment	Claudius
2	23.09.	<i>No on-site class</i> — decentralized working week	—
3	30.09.	Discussion of the entry texts	Anna-Katharina
3	30.09.	Working with data: stylized facts & theory-ladenness of observation	Claudius
4	07.10.	Primer on scientific argumentation	Anna-Katharina
4	07.10.	Primer on poster design and presentation	Anna-Katharina
5	14.10.	<i>No class</i>	—
	21.10.	Trade, externalization, and environmental conflicts	Claudius
6	28.10.	Accounting environmental stressors on the global level	Claudius
7	04.11.	Classical environmental policy instruments	Claudius
7	04.11.	Application: the European Emissions Trading System (EU ETS)	Anna-Katharina
8	11.11.	The growth vs. degrowth debate	Claudius
9	18.11.	Environmental and global justice	Anna-Katharina
10	25.11.	Non-conventional policy instruments	Anna-Katharina
11	02.12.	Work-in-progress country analysis presentations & feedback	Anna-Katharina & Claudius
12	09.12.	Summary & open questions	Anna-Katharina & Claudius
13	16.12.	Poster presentations	Anna-Katharina & Claudius

5 General References

These texts accompany the seminar as a whole; session-specific readings are on the individual session pages linked in the schedule above.

Caney, S. (2021) 'Climate justice', in E. N. Zalta (ed.). *The Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*. Stanford, CA: Metaphysics Research Lab, Stanford University, available at <https://plato.stanford.edu/archives/win2021/entries/justice-climate/> (accessed August 2026).

Common, M. S. and Stagl, S. (2005) *Ecological economics: An introduction*, Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

Coria, J. and Sterner, T. (eds) (2013) *Policy instruments for environmental and natural resource management*, 2nd Edn, New York: Routledge.

Daly, H. E. and Farley, J. C. (2011) *Ecological economics: Principles and applications*, 2nd Edn, Washington, DC: Island Press.

Martínez-Alier, J. and Muradian, R. (eds) (2015) *Handbook of ecological economics*, Cheltenham; Northampton, MA: Edward Elgar Publishing.

Raworth, K. (2017) *Doughnut economics: Seven ways to think like a 21st-century economist*, White River Junction, VT: Chelsea Green Publishing.

6 Evaluation and Assessment

The final mark for the course depends on a group **country-analysis poster** and the students' performance during the final poster presentation. The posters are prepared in groups of up to 3 people and pitched during the poster conference at the end of the semester.

Full details on the poster — the content and guiding questions as well as the examination criteria and assessment dimensions — are on the dedicated **examination page**.

Study Recommendations

I strongly recommend that you spread your study time fairly evenly throughout the semester. It will save you time and effort if you study and practice constantly.

Contact Information

For questions regarding the course content or logistics, please use the [Moodle discussion forums](#).